Chapter 38

Master of My Own Time:
Earning to Serve, without Saboteurs

I QUIT THE INDIAN POLICE SERVICE ON 26 DECEMBER 2007: TO WORK on my terms. Within a week of my retirement I launched something I had wanted to: an e-portal, www.saferindia.com, to facilitate people who needed to register a complaint with the police, and could not, due to indifference or reluctance on the part of the police personnel. In Indian police systems, it is not at easy to get a complaint registered and lodge an FIR (first information report). The e-project presented a novel and foolproof method of registering a complaint, a need that had remained hitherto unfulfilled.

E-PORTAL A PRESSURE GROUP ON POLICE

For some people, 24 hours isn't enough. Celebrated police officer Dr Kiran Bedi, in fact, is trying to pack in 48 hours in a day, post her voluntary retirement … after she was bypassed for post of Delhi police commissioner. This IPS officer … says, 'I don't see any woman making it to the top for some time at least …'

So what is Bedi doing post-retirement? 'At the moment, I'm looking for a day to have 48 hours,' she says emphatically. Her first initiative as a civilian has been to continue work on police reforms. In this context, she launched an e-portal on 3 January [2008], *saferindia.com*, where complainants who are refused help in police stations can write in. This is a project of her NGO, 'India Vision Foundation'. Bedi says, 'Ninety-six per cent of crimes aren't registered. Let the government and people know that a crime can now be registered through this national portal. It'll act as a pressure group on the police. The portal will forward unattended/unacknowledged complaints to respective state police headquarters. The e-mail complaint will be valid proof of receipt which the police cannot ignore or deny'. This initiative comes just after two girls were molested in Mumbai on New Year's eve. Initially, Bedi will be helped by retired police officers, civil servants and law students. Later, she plans to take recourse to RTI [Right to Information Act] and ask the media to do its bit. 'If the media joins us in this drive, we can turn the wheel around in one year.'

She has used her personal savings for this project, but admits her uniform gave her the position to mobilise and raise support for this service. 'I can't give a Rs 1 lakh advertisement in papers, but I can generate awareness and build support.'

Bedi believes policing has the 'power to correct', the 'power to do' and the 'power to get things done'. Little wonder then that her concept of policing was always social service and not power. 'It never was about power for me. I was merely a citizen in uniform. For me, prevention of crime was the priority. I've always encouraged everyone around me to go beyond their family